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Masks of Positivity: Social Performance and Affective Paralysis in Joyce's *Dubliners*

Why does the language of *Dubliners* look so positive? The question might seem odd at first. After all, Joyce himself described Dublin as “the centre of paralysis” in a letter to Grant Richards (Joyce, “Letter to Grant Richards”). Florence L. Walzl argues that *Dubliners* is organized as a “life chronology,” so that the collection moves through the stages of childhood, adolescence, maturity, and public life rather than presenting paralysis as a merely scattered theme (408–15). Traditional readings have undoubtedly focused on Joyce’s scrupulous severity of style and on those moments of epiphany that lay bare his characters’ predicaments. Readers, too, have long felt that gloomy atmosphere: in the failed escape of “Eveline,” in the quiet disillusionment of “A Little Cloud,” and in the snow falling softly on the living and the dead at the close of “The Dead.”

And yet, once we set aside inherited reading habits and look at the text computationally, something unexpected comes into view. Beneath this bleakness, however, runs a surprising layer of pleasure, hope and affirmation. At the level of lexical sentiment, *Dubliners* looks unexpectedly positive. David P. Rando argues that hope in *Dubliners* can function as a “forward-looking process,” one tied to anticipation and unrealized possibility (Rando 53-73). But this surface warmth does not erase the book’s deeper bleakness. On the contrary, it pushes us to ask how feeling is organized within the text.

This pamphlet argues that in *Dubliners*, positive language works mainly as a medium of social performance—politeness, expectation, and habitual expression—rather than a sign of genuine joy. Negative language, by contrast, more directly names loss, fear, death,

and emotional desolation. Yet although the two operate differently, they do not finally lead in opposite directions. They converge on the same affective ground: emotional numbness and unrealized expectation. They belong, in the end, to the same world—one in which social life goes on while people and their feelings are repeatedly brought to a standstill.

To explore this pattern, the discussion begins at the level of vocabulary, then turns to the emotional distribution and affective movement of the fifteen stories, after which it examines keyword contexts and semantic proximity. The aim is not to replace close reading with distant measurement, but to let the two work together in revealing a persistent feature of Joyce's Dublin: the way language can soften paralysis, and yet still leave it unmistakably visible.

1. The Lexical Surface of Emotion

Before sentiment analysis, simply attending to *Dubliners*' lexical surface already offers a sense of the world it builds. Any subsequent finding of "positivity," after all, must rest on a linguistic layer that can first be registered statistically. To identify that layer, I lemmatized and part-of-speech tagged the text, then examined the most frequent nouns, verbs, and adjectives. The figure below retains only those lemmas with stronger semantic weight so that what emerges is a more meaningful set of terms that captures the lexical surface of *Dubliners* itself.¹

¹ The frequency figures are based on lemmatized and part-of-speech tagged output. Proper names, titles such as *aunt* and *Mr* and other high-frequency words with limited interpretive value were excluded, so the figure does not reproduce the raw frequency list exactly, but offers a filtered view of the lexical categories most relevant to interpretation.

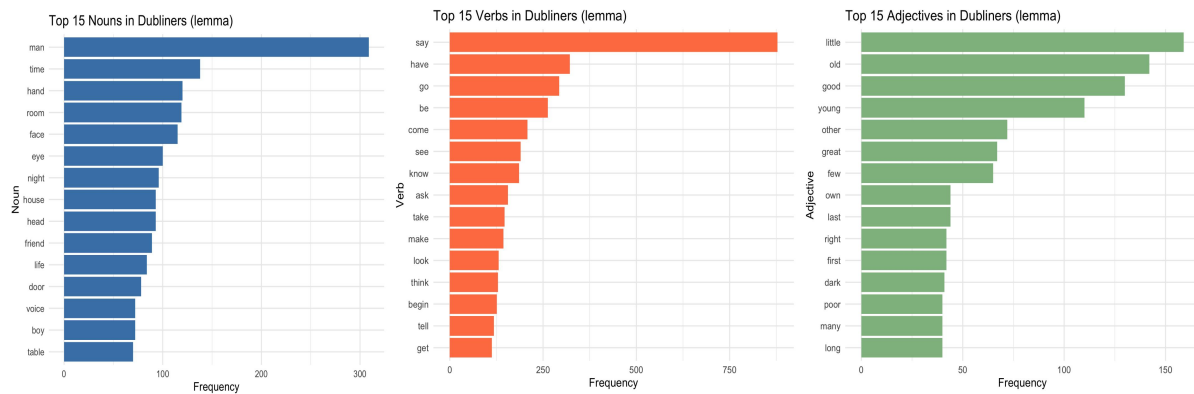


Fig. 1. High-frequency nouns, verbs, and adjectives in *Dubliners* (lemmatized and filtered).

Among the nouns, the most frequent item is *man* (309), but more revealing is the cluster that surrounds it: *room* (120), *house* (93), *door* (78), and *table* (69), together with *hand* (121), *face* (116), *eye* (100), *head* (93), and *voice* (72). It is a world centred on people and the texture of their everyday lives. This is not an expansive public realm but an enclosed, bodily, interior one, structured by limited contact and narrow spaces of encounter. Even words such as *time* (139) and *life* (84) do not orient the text toward broader history or futurity; they remain tied to local and immediate experience. At the level of the noun, the affective atmosphere of *Dubliners* is marked less by openness than by enclosure, repetition, and constraint.

The verbs transform that enclosure into a mode of social life — or, more precisely, into a failure of action. *Say* (884) dominates the list by an overwhelming margin, far outpacing *go* (296), *come* (210), *see* (192), *know* (188), *look* (133), and *think* (131). What this distribution foregrounds is not the propulsion of action, but speech, observation, thought, and judgment. The dominant verbal world of *Dubliners* is thus sustained by utterance and perception rather than by decisive action. The characters are not immobile; yet their movements rarely issue in transformation.

Most closely related to the paradox of positivity, however, are the adjectives. The most frequent include *little* (159), *old* (142), *good* (130), and *young* (110), followed by *great* (67), *dark* (41), and *poor* (40). Crucial here is the tonal heterogeneity of this list. *Little* and

old render the world diminished, worn, and constrained; *dark* and *poor* deepen that impression through registers of deprivation and shadow. Yet *good* and *young* are just as conspicuous, and considerably more frequent than *dark* or *poor*. The lexical surface of *Dubliners*, then, is not governed by overtly negative modifiers alone. More precisely, it juxtaposes age, constraint, and want with quotidian affirmation, evaluation, and faint brightness. The result is a curiously stratified surface.

These frequency figures establish the precondition for the sentiment analysis that follows. They show that Joyce's Dublin is a closed, interior, bodily world sustained by perception and speech, while also indicating that its descriptive lexicon is not organized by darkness or despair alone. Words such as *good* and *young* already occupy the high-frequency layer, producing an unstable yet genuine surface of mild positivity. The question, then, is not whether such words negate the collection's bleakness, but how this quantified lexical surface reshapes our reading of *Dubliners* as a whole.

2. Patterns of Sentiment Across Stories

Having established a preliminary impression of *Dubliners*' lexical surface, the next question is: what overall image emerges once that surface is quantified by sentiment analysis?

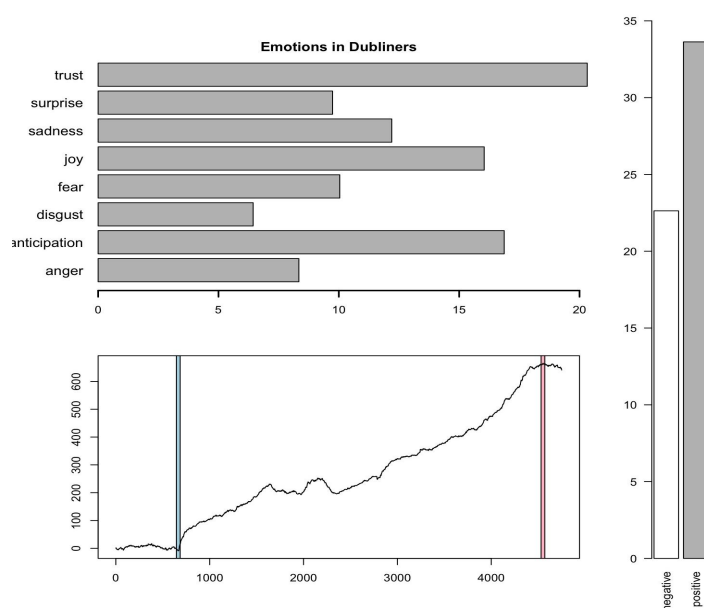


Fig. 2. Overall sentiment patterns in *Dubliners*. Left column: distribution of eight NRC emotion categories and cumulative sentiment trajectory; right: proportion of positive versus negative words.

Figure 2 shows that positive words exceed negative ones by roughly 48 percent overall; the cumulative sentiment curve rises across most of the collection, despite local fluctuations at the beginning and end; and among the NRC emotion categories, the most prominent are not sadness or fear but trust and anticipation, followed by joy.² This reveals a paradox: far from being dominated by negativity, *Dubliners* registers a counterintuitive brightness that seems ill-suited to a work so often read under the sign of paralysis. Yet this should not be mistaken for evidence that Joyce secretly wrote a “happy book,” rather, beneath that surface of mild positivity lies precisely the key to understanding *Dubliners*.

But an overall portrait of the collection, however revealing, is not enough. We must turn to the individual stories—to make the data more tangible, more concrete.³

² Sentiment scores were generated in R using the *syuzhet* package with the NRC lexicon.

³ To avoid distortions that would arise from comparing cumulative sentiment across stories of unequal length, the analysis here uses mean sentiment per sentence rather than raw cumulative values.

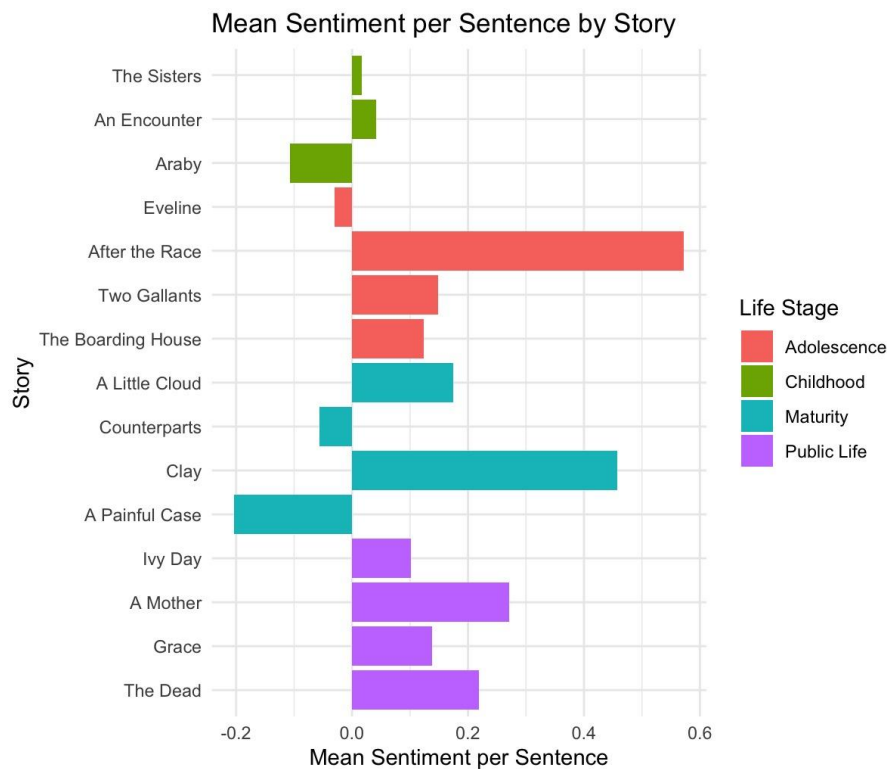


Fig. 3. Mean sentiment per sentence across the fifteen stories of *Dubliners*.

Figure 3 shows that only four of the fifteen stories register a negative mean sentiment; the remaining eleven are positive to varying degrees. “After the Race” (0.57) stands at the highest end, followed by “Clay” (0.46); at the opposite extreme lie “A Painful Case” (-0.20) and “Araby” (-0.11). What emerges from this distribution is a tentative pattern: higher sentiment values tend to appear in stories structured around sociability, festivity, ritual, or other forms of public performance, whereas lower values more often accompany narratives that confront loneliness, death, shame, or disillusionment directly. “After the Race” is saturated with speed, money, nocturnal glamour, and social excitement, even though that excitement ends in loss; “Clay,” likewise, is wrapped in the mild warmth of a family visit and seasonal custom. By contrast, “A Painful Case” traces Mr. Duffy’s withdrawal from intimacy into a life of solitary routine, culminating in a lonely night of belated recognition; “Araby” follows a boy’s hopeful quest to a bazaar that collapses into darkness and shame. Both move

more directly toward exposure to loss. Positivity, then, is not evenly spread—it clusters around specific narrative situations.

But if we push further: does this tendency remain stable within each story?

Story	Stage	Overall	Ending	Drop	Trend
A Little Cloud	Maturity	0.17	-0.43	0.6	Sharp Drop
After the Race	Adolescence	0.57	0.08	0.49	Sharp Drop
The Dead	Public Life	0.22	-0.21	0.43	Sharp Drop
The Sisters	Childhood	0.02	-0.23	0.25	Drop
A Painful Case	Maturity	-0.2	-0.44	0.24	Drop
Eveline	Adolescence	-0.03	-0.24	0.21	Drop
A Mother	Public Life	0.27	0.08	0.19	Drop
An Encounter	Childhood	0.04	-0.14	0.18	Drop
Ivy Day	Public Life	0.1	-0.05	0.15	Moderate Drop
Two Gallants	Adolescence	0.15	0.04	0.11	Moderate Drop
Counterparts	Maturity	-0.06	-0.1	0.04	Flat
Araby	Childhood	-0.11	-0.12	0.01	Flat
Clay	Maturity	0.46	0.56	-0.1	Slight Rise
Grace	Public Life	0.14	0.27	-0.13	Slight Rise
The Boarding House	Adolescence	0.12	0.3	-0.18	Rise

Fig. 4. Ending sentiment versus overall sentiment: shifts in the final 10 percent of each story.

Figure 4 sharpens the question by comparing each story's overall mean sentiment with the mean sentiment of its ending. The result is remarkably consistent: twelve of the fifteen stories end below their own overall mean.⁴ This means that even when a story registers a relatively positive score on the whole, that positivity is often unstable and tends to decline. More importantly, the declines tend to occur at structurally revealing moments: when social atmosphere thins out, when fantasy gives way to consequence, or when an earlier hopeful surface can no longer hold. "A Little Cloud" provides the sharpest example, dropping from 0.17 to -0.43 as Little Chandler's private reverie gives way to domestic humiliation; "After the Race," despite having the highest overall score, falls from 0.57 to 0.08 once the evening's exhilaration yields to the fact that he "had lost heavily" (Joyce 47); and "The Dead," positive

⁴ For Figure 4, each story's ending is defined as its final 10 percent, compared with that story's overall mean sentiment. The trend scale follows this standard: sharp drop (shift ≥ 0.30), drop ($0.15 < \text{shift} \leq 0.30$), moderate drop ($0.05 < \text{shift} \leq 0.15$), flat ($-0.05 < \text{shift} < 0.05$), slight rise ($-0.15 \leq \text{shift} < -0.05$), and rise (shift ≥ -0.15).

on average, descends to -0.21 as Gabriel's final vision widens toward "all the living and the dead" (Joyce 257), swept toward a vast awareness of death. As for the exceptions—"Clay," "Grace," and "The Boarding House," where the endings rise slightly—that rise does not amount to happiness. More precisely, this rise is a form of social smoothing-over: conflicts are temporarily settled, but never truly resolved. Thus the "positivity" revealed by Figure 2 becomes, in Figure 3, significantly qualified. The mildly positive tendency observed proves difficult to sustain; it weakens, breaks, or turns downward at the endings. It is a surface that narrative temporarily maintains, not an emotional destination the stories finally reach.

Taken together, these three figures yield a more precise account of the paradox: *Dubliners* looks more positive than its reputation suggests overall, but that "positivity" is unevenly distributed across stories and tends to weaken or reverse at the endings. The question, then, is no longer whether positivity exists, but what kind of language produces it—and that requires moving beyond scores into the actual workings of words in context.

3. Positive and Negative Words in Context: KWIC Close Reading

The second part of our analysis has shown what *Dubliners* looks like in terms of sentiment scores. But to grasp how these words actually work—and what effects they produce—we must move beyond quantitative measures and combine computational analysis with close reading. The KWIC returns sentiment analysis to the texture of the narrative itself. I first extracted all words tagged as positive or negative by the NRC lexicon, mapped their frequencies across the text, and then, while preserving full contextual information, conducted KWIC searches for several high-frequency keywords, selecting the most interpretable examples.⁵ The keywords discussed here are not a mechanical inventory of the most common

⁵ KWIC queries were run on full-text tokens with punctuation removed but without stopword removal, using a window of eight words on either side of the target term. Candidate keywords were drawn from NRC-tagged

words but a set of representative terms that possess frequency, contextual stability, and interpretive weight.⁶

Consider first the positive words. *Good* appears 101 times—very high frequency that demands attention. Yet in *Dubliners*, good rarely signifies genuine moral or emotional value. More often, it serves utility, evaluation, and phatic conversation. In “An Encounter,” the old man insists that “there was nothing would do him any good but a good sound whipping. A slap on the hand or a box on the ear was no good” (Joyce 23). Here, *good* does not signify moral value at all. It means usefulness in the first and third cases, and in the middle phrase it serves only to strengthen the brutality of “whipping.” In “Two Gallants,” “there’s nothing to touch a good slavey” is a piece of evaluative language that registers not praise but perceived utility (Joyce 52). And the recurrent “good evening” is little more than a polite gesture, a formula that keeps social interaction running without substance. *Hope* deepens this pattern. The collection opens with the line: “There was no hope for him this time: it was the third stroke” (Joyce 3). Here *hope* first appears in a negated form, tethered from the outset to hopelessness and futility. Elsewhere, when characters say “I hope to God he’ll not leave us in the lurch,” the word registers less as fulfilled promise than as anxious expectation—waiting, guessing, and deferral become the common things of social life (Joyce 132). *Love* follows the same logic. “One human being had seemed to love him” (Joyce 128). What governs the meaning here is not *love* but *seemed*. Love never materializes as a mutual relation but becomes a retrospective recognition, a possibility acknowledged only after it has been lost.

positive and negative words ranked by their actual frequency in the text, then narrowed through manual review of concordance lines for interpretive relevance.

⁶ The close-reading set does not reproduce the raw frequency list mechanically. Low-explanatory or misleadingly tagged items—including relational labels such as *aunt* and anomalous positive tags such as *don’t*—were excluded from analysis.

So positive words in *Dubliners* do not open the door to a brighter world. They provide a surface order—politeness, deferral, retrospection—through which characters sustain a semblance of social functioning. But that surface rarely translates into reality.

Negative words, by contrast, operate with greater directness. They are less mediated by social performance. *Cold* is a telling case. In the sentence like “The night was cold and gloomy” (Joyce 127), the word translates external environment directly into felt oppression. *Death* works similarly. In “A Painful Case,” Duffy’s realization culminates in the recognition that he “had sentenced her to ignominy, a death of shame” (Joyce 127). In “The Dead,” meanwhile, death expands into the shared horizon of “all the living and the dead” (Joyce 257). Also, in “The Sisters,” the boy says of the dead priest: “It filled me with fear, and yet I longed to be nearer to it” (Joyce 3). *Fear* is just a raw feeling, named plainly here. Compared to positive words, these negative terms do less to sustain social readability. They name directly what is felt and what is lost.

But the crucial point is not simply to dismiss positive words as false and negative ones as true. Rather, positive and negative words perform different kinds of linguistic work in *Dubliners*. Positive words maintain a social surface that remains operational—characters can still exchange pleasantries, form expectations, make evaluations, sustain relationships. Negative words mark the points where that surface gives way: to cold, shame, death, loss. Though the two sets of words are opposed in the lexicon, they converge in the same fictional world. Thus the importance of positive language in *Dubliners* does not lie in its capacity to offset bleakness. It lies, instead, in its ability to wrap bleakness in a more socially sustainable form—one in which life can still be lived, even if not truly moved forward.

4. Semantic Proximity and Affective Convergence

If KWIC reveals how words function within local contexts, this section turns to their broader semantic neighbourhoods. The question is no longer what a word means on its own, but what kinds of terms it tends to inhabit similar environments with across *Dubliners*, and what sort of semantic terrain those affinities begin to trace. Figure 5 makes this pattern visible, and what matters most here is proximity rather than position.⁷

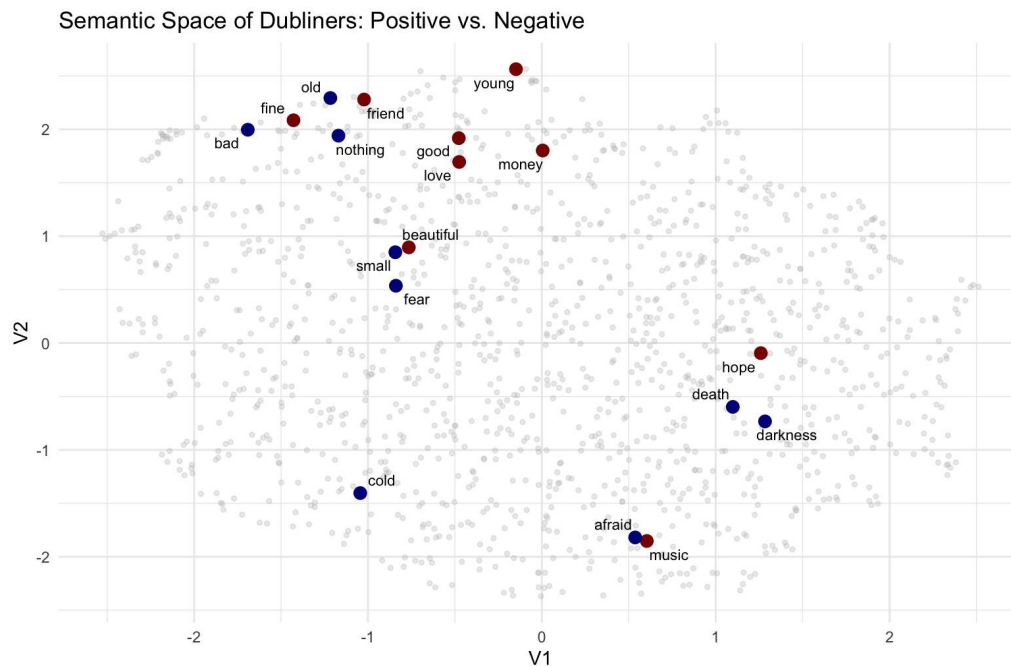


Fig. 5. Semantic proximity between selected positive and negative words in *Dubliners*.

What proves most striking is a set of stable and suggestive adjacencies. *Hope*, for instance, does not gravitate toward a brighter or more expansive semantic zone; it sits instead near *death* and *darkness*. Hope in *Dubliners*, then, does not automatically open onto futurity or promise. It often arrives already shadowed by ending and negation. *Friend*, meanwhile, appears close to *old* and *nothing*. That proximity is especially telling, since it implies that

⁷ Figure 5 models semantic relation through word co-occurrence across the collection. Word vectors were trained on a weighted co-occurrence matrix and projected into two dimensions for visualization. It should therefore be read relationally: what matters is relative proximity among terms, not absolute position. Highlighted terms are representative keywords whose semantic neighborhoods illuminate *Dubliners*' affective structure; low-value function-like items and tagging anomalies are excluded.

friendship in Joyce does not reliably guarantee intimacy, vitality, or warmth; it is often embedded in the same semantic atmosphere as diminishment, vacancy, and arrest. Most arresting of all is the placement of *music* near *afraid*. The relation disrupts any easy assumption that aesthetic experience naturally tends toward pleasure or release. In this collection, music is fully capable of drawing fear, exposure, and emotional vulnerability into its orbit.

These terms, in other words, do not divide into two cleanly bounded territories in Joyce's verbal world. They share environments, lean into one another, and return again and again to the same affective ground. That is why the positivity of *Dubliners* feels so peculiar. It does not name a separate realm outside darkness. It marks, instead, a socially legible surface within it—a mode of language through which social life remains speakable, even as loss, fear, and immobility continue to press beneath it.

Overall, computational methods let us see a dimension of the text that ordinary interpretation can feel but finds hard to measure, a recurring lexicon of approval, hope, sociability, and muted affirmation that keeps feeling aloft even where fulfilment is barely on offer. In Joyce, positive language is not the counterpoint to numbness or loss, it operates as a form of social performance, sustaining a surface of warmth and expectation even as the stories repeatedly arrive at affective paralysis. It is one of the shapes those conditions assume once they slip into everyday speech, ritual exchange, and social conduct.

All the same, the method has evident limits. Lexicon-based sentiment analysis cannot capture tone or irony, nor can it reliably tell sincere hope from the habit of hoping; it often falters when asked to separate emotional truth from the particular work a phrase is performing. Yet that limitation is instructive too, because *Dubliners* is itself deeply attached to surfaces that remain socially legible while affectively unstable. A natural next move would be to sort positive keywords more systematically by function, trace how those functions alter

across the fifteen stories, and ask whether Joyce's four life stages yield genuinely distinct emotional structures, or merely restage the same pattern at different scales.

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